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THE INSOMNIAC'S DREAM DEBUT

AFTER THE initial excitement wore off, my maiden tour to the West Indies was all about fear and introspection. Of course, I was just a young boy and excited to be in the position I was in. But I was quite apprehensive about my father's financial situation. I was scared about what would happen to my family if I didn't succeed. Every time I walked out of the dressing room to the field, my family's near-bankruptcy played on my mind.

When we U-19 players boarded that flight from Karachi, we were just *londas* and *laparas* – boys and sloggers. Many of us hadn't even seen the inside of an aircraft till then. After flying for hours, when we landed in the Caribbean and faced obstacles and scandals and endured them together, those interactions and experiences turned into lifelong friendships, not just amongst the Pakistani bunch, but also our opponents on the tour – Sarwan, Hinds, Gayle, King. What a great first tour for a bunch of young boys!

However, after that 'toothbrush call' by Haroon Rasheed, nothing was the same anymore. Too bad my folks suspected my involvement in the Zeeshan Pervaiz controversy – they thought I was being grounded and sacked. Yet, everything after that call is today a blur, and for good reason.

I remember the difficult itinerary: Barabados to Guyana, Guyana to London, London to Dubai, Dubai to Karachi, one hour in Karachi – with just a few minutes with my family, who got me my gear – and then from Karachi back to Dubai, and then off to Nairobi. By the time I boarded the flight for Nairobi, I was too tired to sleep. I did not sleep for a minute. How could I? All I was thinking of – the only thing I could – was how, in a few hours, I was going to be with the very guys every Pakistani kid knew about and wanted to emulate. What would meeting them be like? How would the dressing room be? Would Wasim Akram indeed be as tall as I'd heard he was? How strong would Waqar Younis's handshake be? How big was Inzi? Would these names I'd grown up dreaming about be nice to me? Or would they be mean and curt? Would they even acknowledge me, a teenager? Would I be picked on? Would there be an initiation into the team? Honestly, I couldn't deal with it. By the time I landed in Nairobi, I was tired, but full of